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DDS MARINE WEEKLY MARITIME INTELLIGENCE

TANKERS | ENERGY | STS | COMPLIANCE

Insight. Safety. Excellence.

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Executive Market Dashboard

Marketsnapshot: 06 August 2026 | Freight narrative based on oil price.com, Ship & Bunker and Hellenic Shipping News weekly data

BRENT CRUDE

US\$79.18/bbl

▼ 0.34% intraday

WTI CRUDE

US\$74.80/bbl

▼ 0.56% intraday

SINGAPORE VLSFO

US\$844.50/mt

▲ US\$4.50d/d

SINGAPORE MGO

US\$1,205.00/mt

▲ US\$3.50 d/d

BALTIC DRY INDEX

3,063 pts

▲ 2-month high

BRENT, WEEK-ON-WEEK

-11.7%

vs US\$89.68c lose, 31 Jul

DDS VIEW

Oil has fallen sharply since our last issue — Brent is off more than eleven percent from its 31 July close as markets price in reports of a draft de-escalation arrangement around the Strait of Hormuz. But the physical market has not caught up with the financial one. Hormuz tanker traffic remains stalled near a two-month low despite the reported peace signals, Ukraine's maritime drone campaign has cut dirty tanker loadings from Russian Black Sea and Sea of Azov ports by 62% in the last two weeks of July, and UN trade data shows Hormuz-dependent economies still running at roughly half their normal export volumes. For Southeast Asian operators, falling headline crude prices should not be read as a falling risk premium. Screening, war-risk allocation and route documentation remain conditions precedent on any Gulf, Red Sea or Black Sea-linked fixture.

This Week at a Glance

- **Oil:** Brent US\$79.18/bbl and WTI US\$74.80/bbl on 6 August, extending a sharp slide from US\$89.68/US\$86.80 at the 31 July close as reports emerge of a draft Hormuz agreement awaiting approval from Iran's Supreme Leader.
- **Bunkers:** Singapore VLSFO US\$844.50/mt and MGO US\$1,205.00/mt, still trading well inside their recent US\$797–873/mt and US\$1,127–1,355/mt ranges despite the crude pullback.
- **Freight:** The Baltic Dry Index rose for a fifth straight session to 3,063 points, a two-month high, led by a 6.6% surge in the Capesize segment.
- **Compliance:** OFAC (29 July) designated two Iran-linked entities — Persian Gulf Marine Insurance Company and HormuzSafe Marine Services Authority — accused of running an IRGC-backed mandatory "insurance" scheme for vessels transiting Hormuz, alongside further tanker and shipping-network designations.
- **Route security:** Dirty tanker loadings from Russian Black Sea and Sea of Azov ports fell 62% in the final two weeks of July following Ukraine's Operation MoLoChKa drone campaign; Russia has suspended navigation through the Kerch Strait and Don- Azov Canal.



CEO Market Commentary

Capt. Dinesh Naidu KC—Founder & Chairman, DDS Marine Group

“A falling oil price is not the same thing as a falling risk. This week, the gap between the two is the whole story.”

Since our last issue, the tanker market has been handed a genuinely rare event: a double-digit percentage fall in crude prices inside a single week, driven not by a demand shock but by reported diplomatic progress on the Strait of Hormuz. That is unambiguously good news if it holds. It is not, on its own, a reason to relax operational discipline.

Three things should keep owners, charterers and service providers in Southeast Asia cautious. First, Hormuz tanker traffic itself has not moved with the price — reporting this week describes transits stalling near a two-month low even as peace talk headlines circulate, which tells us the people actually moving ships through the Strait are still pricing real risk, not headline risk. Second, Ukraine's escalating maritime drone campaign in the Black Sea and Sea of Azov has cut Russian and Kazakh dirty tanker loadings by well over half in a fortnight, is reportedly reaching further offshore toward Western-flagged tonnage, and is already showing up in wider Cape of Good Hope routing for cargoes that would once have transited more direct corridors. Third, UN trade-agency data this week put hard numbers on what six months of Hormuz disruption has actually done to physical trade — a 54% year-on-year fall in combined export volumes of twelve strategic energy, fertilizer and industrial products from the Gulf's Hormuz-dependent economies. Diplomatic de-escalation, if confirmed, will unwind that only gradually.

For Malaysia and the wider Southeast Asian region, the practical implication is unchanged from Issue 001: this remains a risk-allocation market before it is a freight market. War-risk premiums, AIS and routing documentation, sanctions screening timed close to fixture and performance, and insurance verification are not seasonal precautions to be eased when oil prices soften — they are the cost of doing business safely in a chokepoint-dependent trade that has not yet returned to its pre-conflict baseline.

DDS Marine Group's objective with this publication remains the same: to give owners, charterers and operators active in our waters — the Strait of Malacca, the Singapore Strait and the Johor STS/bunkering corridor — a grounded, operator's read of what is actually changing, distinct from the headline volatility in crude benchmarks.

Capt. Dinesh Naidu KC

Founder & Chairman, DDS Marine Group

Publication Principle — Independent operational commentary based on publicly available market information from oilprice.com, Ship & Bunker and Hellenic Shipping News. No proprietary broker assessments are reproduced.



● Global Oil Market

Prices and the week's directional move, per oilprice.com and Ship & Bunker historical series

Indicator	Latest	Reading
Brent crude	US\$79.18/ bbl	Down 0.34% intraday, 6 Aug; down ~11.7% from the US\$89.68 close on 31 Jul.
WTI crude	US\$74.80/ bbl	Down 0.56% intraday, 6 Aug; down ~13.8% from the US\$86.80 close on 31 Jul.
Murban crude	US\$77.94/ bbl	Up 1.41% intraday — Gulf grade holding a narrower discount to Brent than usual as Hormuz risk repricing plays out unevenly across benchmarks.
US crude & product inventories	Mixed	EIA's latest weekly report showed crude inventories rising while gasoline and distillate stocks declined, per Hellenic Shipping News (6 Aug).

Market Interpretation

The scale of this week's move is unusual. Brent has fallen from a 31 July close of US\$89.68/bbl to US\$79.18/bbl on 6 August — a decline of close to twelve percent in under a week — as oilprice.com reporting points to a draft Hormuz de-escalation arrangement reportedly awaiting approval from Iran's Supreme Leader, alongside the earlier halt to threatened Iran strikes. Markets have moved quickly to price out geopolitical risk premium.

The physical market has been slower to follow. Reporting this week separately describes Hormuz tanker traffic as remaining subdued and stalling near a two-month low even as peace-talk headlines circulate — a signal that commercial operators, insurers and flag administrations are still treating the Strait as high-risk pending confirmed, durable de-escalation rather than draft-stage reports.

DDS BASE CASE

We expect continued two-way volatility around any Hormuz diplomatic headline. A confirmed, ratified agreement — as opposed to a "draft awaiting approval" — would be needed before we would expect tanker traffic, insurance terms and war-risk premiums to normalise. Until then, the gap between financial-market pricing and physical-market caution is itself the trade to watch.

Commercial Effect on Shipping

A fast, large downward move in crude and bunker costs improves voyage economics and working-capital requirements in the near term, but it should not be read as a signal to loosen war-risk, insurance or routing terms in charter-parties. Owners and charterers fixing into the Gulf, Red Sea or Black Sea this week should treat the current price relief as provisional until the reported Hormuz arrangement is confirmed and reflected in actual transit volumes and underwriting terms.



◆ Crude Tanker Market

VLCC, Suezmax and Aframax directional assessment

Segment	Current Tone	Primary Driver
VLCC	Cautiously firm / headline-sensitive	Hormuz diplomatic signals vs. still-subdued physical transits
Suezmax	Volatile, route-disrupted	Black Sea/Sea of Azov drone campaign; Cape diversions widening
Aframax	Firm, regionally exposed	Red Sea/Bab el-Mandeb Houthi activity; Black Sea dislocation

VLCC

Reporting this week (oilprice.com) describes Hormuz tanker traffic stalling at a two-month low even as reports circulate of a draft de-escalation arrangement reportedly awaiting approval from Iran's Supreme Leader. That divergence — falling headline oil prices against traffic that has not recovered — is the defining feature of the VLCC market this week. Owners with clean compliance histories and documented routing continue to command a premium; charterers should treat "peace talk" headlines as a reason for heightened diligence, not relaxed screening, until transit volumes actually respond.

Suezmax

The Suezmax segment is being reshaped by the Black Sea. BIMCO's Chief Shipping Analyst, Niels Rasmussen, reports that dirty tanker loadings from Russian Black Sea and Sea of Azov ports fell 62% in the final two weeks of July compared with the prior four-week average — from 2.59 million barrels per day down to 0.98 million bpd — following Ukraine's Operation MoLoChKa maritime drone campaign, which began in the Sea of Azov on 6 July and expanded into the Black Sea on 15 July. Kazakh dirty exports via the CPC Novorossiysk terminal fell by a similar 62%, despite roughly 75% of that terminal's year-to-date volumes being EU-bound. Aframax and Suezmax tonnage, which have split Russian Black Sea/Azov volumes roughly 20/80 this year, have seen comparable reductions. Separately, reporting this week describes Ukrainian drones reaching Western-flagged tonnage in the Black Sea, alongside widening Saudi cargo diversions around the Cape of Good Hope — both consistent with rising tonne-mile demand on routes that avoid, rather than replace, the disrupted corridor.

Aframax

Aframax earnings remain exposed to Red Sea security. This week's headlines include a Houthi claim of a ballistic-missile hit on a Saudi oil tanker, the sinking of an India-flagged cargo vessel off Yemen, and a reported surge in "dark" (AIS-off) tanker transits at Bab el-Mandeb as the Houthi threat persists. Combined with Black Sea dislocation, the segment continues to benefit from replacement-barrel movements and shorter-haul redirected cargo, but remains highly exposed to local security incidents and to the compliance risk created by dark transits.

DDS VIEW

BIMCO's own arithmetic is worth sitting with: Russian and Kazakh Black Sea/Azov dirty loadings made up around 5% of global dirty tanker volumes year-to-date, and if the current reduced loading rate persists, BIMCO estimates global dirty tanker volumes could fall a further 3% — on top of a 5.6% year-on-year decline already recorded in 2026. That is a meaningful tightening of effective dirty-tanker supply layered directly on top of Hormuz uncertainty. We would treat any near-term softening in headline oil prices as background noise against that structural tonnage story, not as a signal that the market has de-risked.



◆ Clean & Product Tankers

LR2, MR and refining-margin implications

Refining-margin support for the product tanker complex remains intact. oilprice.com's editorial coverage this week describes the ongoing Middle East conflict as having tightened global fuel supplies and pushed refining margins to record highs, with Strait of Hormuz disruption, reduced Asian refining runs and export restrictions squeezing diesel, gasoline and jet-fuel markets simultaneously. Separately, extreme heat and drought across Europe are reported to be cutting refinery efficiency and forcing cuts to nuclear and hydropower generation — a second, independent driver pushing diesel refining margins toward multi-decade highs.

Segment	Opportunity	Risk
LR2	Long-haul middle-distillate and naphtha movements benefiting from Middle East/Asia dislocation and record refining margins.	High bunker exposure; route security overlap with the Aframax trading economics described opposite.
MR	Flexible regional distribution and replacement cargoes as refiners reroute around Hormuz-linked supply gaps.	Port congestion and fast-changing arbitrage economics as crude benchmarks swing sharply week to week.
Handy / Specialised	Regional supply, chemicals and smaller-port access, less exposed to headline Gulf volatility.	Cargo compatibility, vetting and tank-cleanliness documentation remain the binding constraints.

DDS VIEW

The product tanker story this week is really two independent supply shocks arriving together — Middle East conflict-driven refining disruption, and a European heatwave cutting refinery efficiency and power availability at the same time. Both push in the same direction: tighter refined-product supply and firmer long-haul tonne-mile demand for LR2 and MR tonnage carrying replacement cargoes. For charterers, that argues for evaluating freight alongside cargo value and financing cost rather than against headline crude, which has moved in the opposite direction this week.



Bunker Market — Singapore & Global Benchmark

Current indications in US\$/mt, Ship & Bunker (shipandbunker.com), 6 August 2026

Grade	Singapore Price	Day Change	Recent High	Recent Low
VLSFO	US\$844.50/mt	▲ +US\$4.50	US\$873.00	US\$797.00
MGO	US\$1,205.00/mt	▲ +US\$3.50	US\$1,355.00	US\$1,127.00
IFO380	US\$588.00/mt	▲ +US\$13.50	US\$600.00	US\$572.50

Singapore vs. Other Bunkering Hubs (VLSFO, US\$/mt)

Port	VLSFO	Day Change
Singapore	844.50	+4.50
Hong Kong	850.00	+16.50
Fujairah	804.50	+5.50
LA / Long Beach	824.00	+6.50
Santos	825.50	+16.50
Houston	680.00	-35.00
Rotterdam	662.00	-7.00
New York	658.50	-33.50

Interpretation

Singapore VLSFO at US\$844.50/mt sits comfortably within its recent US\$797–873/mt trading range and is up on the day even as crude benchmarks fall sharply — a reminder that bunker pricing lags and only partially tracks crude, and remains sensitive to regional refinery output, blending economics and the compliance-cost overlay (EU ETS, methanol-equivalent pricing) layered on conventional fuel grades. Asia/Pacific bunker prices are broadly firmer week-on-week even as the Americas region has pulled back, consistent with continued tightness in Asian product supply flagged in our Clean & Product Tankers section opposite.

Singapore's VLSFO premium to Fujairah (US\$844.50 vs US\$804.50) and discount to Hong Kong (US\$850.00) leaves it broadly mid-pack among Asia/Pacific hubs this week, while its premium to European and US Gulf ports remains wide — a reminder for owners bunkering in the region that voyage-level fuel-cost planning should reference the specific port pair rather than a single regional benchmark.

Compliance cost note: Ship & Bunker's EU ETS compliance-cost series puts the EUA-VLSFO equivalent surcharge at roughly US\$301/mt this week (EUA at €81.60), a material addition to voyage cost for EU-linked calls that should be reflected explicitly in bunker and freight clauses.

◆ Geopolitical & Route Risk

Hormuz, Red Sea, Bab el-Mandeb and the Black Sea / Sea of Azov

Area	Current Signal	Commercial Consequence
Strait of Hormuz	Draft de-escalation arrangement reportedly awaiting approval from Iran's Supreme Leader; physical transits remain stalled near a two-month low.	Insurance, routing approval, crew welfare and owner consent decisions should not yet assume normalisation.
Red Sea / Bab el-Mandeb	Houthi's claim a missile hit on a Saudi tanker; an India-flagged cargo vessel was sunk off Yemen; dark (AIS-off) transits reported surging.	Elevated K&R and hull-war risk; AIS-gap decisions require documented, defensible justification.
Black Sea / Sea of Azov	Ukraine's Operation MoLoChKa drone campaign has cut Russian/Kazakh dirty loadings 62% in two weeks; Kerch Strait and Don-Azov Canal navigation suspended.	Replacement-barrel demand, wider Cape of Good Hope routing, and rising Suezmax/Aframax tonne-miles.
Hormuz-dependent trade (broader)	UN trade data shows a 54% year-on-year fall in combined export volumes of 12 strategic products from Bahrain, Iran, Iraq, Kuwait, Qatar, Saudi Arabia and the UAE.	Structural demand redirection toward alternative suppliers, with import markets adapting unevenly.

Black Sea Drone Campaign — The Numbers

BIMCO's Niels Rasmussen reports that dirty tanker loadings from Russian Black Sea and Sea of Azov ports averaged 0.98 million barrels per day in the final two weeks of July, down 62% from the prior four-week average of 2.59 million bpd. Ukraine's Operation MoLoChKa began in the Sea of Azov on 6 July, expanded into the Black Sea on 15 July, and by 28 July Ukraine claimed over 200 vessels had been attacked. The campaign has reportedly contributed to Russia suspending navigation through the Kerch Strait and Don-Azov Canal. Kazakh exports via the CPC Novorossiysk terminal — some 75% of which are year-to-date EU-bound — have been hit equally hard. India, the single largest year-to-date destination for Russian Black Sea/Azov dirty cargo at 25% of volumes, has seen a 66% decrease over the same fortnight. Separately, reporting this week describes the drone campaign's reach extending toward Western-flagged tonnage, alongside widening Saudi cargo diversions around the Cape of Good Hope.

Trade Impact — ITC/UNCTAD/WTO Analysis

The International Trade Centre's analysis, published this week, quantifies six months of Hormuz disruption on twelve strategic energy, fertilizer and industrial products for which Hormuz-dependent economies are major global suppliers. Combined export volumes from Bahrain, Iran, Iraq, Kuwait, Qatar, Saudi Arabia and the UAE fell 54% between April 2025 and April 2026 — LNG down 95%, urea 83%, methanol 80%, ammonia 75%; polypropylene was least affected at –24%. Crude petroleum exports fell 28 million tonnes, the largest single loss. Import impact was uneven: Japan, historically 91% Hormuz-sourced, saw a 64% fall in crude imports, with Korea and Malaysia similarly exposed, while Thailand's imports rose 62% as refiners secured alternative cargoes. Alternative suppliers increased shipments for 10 of the 12 products, but fully offset the shortfall only for ammonia and polypropylene — trade diversion is under way but incomplete.

Industry Response — Hormuz Toll Concerns

Shipping-industry bodies this week issued a joint open letter opposing compulsory tolls or charges in the Strait of Hormuz — alongside OFAC's parallel designation (see Compliance Watch, opposite) of Iran-linked entities running a mandatory maritime "insurance" scheme for transiting vessels. Two sides of the same commercial and compliance risk facing owners and operators in the corridor.

DDS RISK LEVEL: HIGH — Diplomatic and price signals have improved, but transit volumes, insurance terms and AIS/routing behaviour have not confirmed it. Treat Gulf, Red Sea or Black Sea fixtures on the same conditions-precedent basis as Issue 001: operational, insurance, sanctions and route approvals in writing before performance.



◆ Sanctions & Compliance Watch

Actionable controls for fixtures and STS operations

Regulatory Developments — Week Ending 6 August 2026

- **United States (OFAC), 29 July 2026** : Treasury designated Persian Gulf Marine Insurance Company and HormuzSafe Marine Services Authority, alleged IRGC-linked entities operating a mandatory maritime "insurance" scheme that forces vessels transiting the Strait of Hormuz to purchase IRGC-brokered coverage, including digital-asset payment channels designed to evade sanctions. The same action designated tankers including **YEHOPE** (IMO 9243320, Barbados-flagged) and **WELL SAIL** (IMO 9321938, Marshall Islands-flagged), plus further vessels linked to the Mohammad Hossein Shamkhani network, which Treasury says has now seen over 200 individuals, entities and vessels sanctioned in total.
- **United States (OFAC), late July–early August 2026** : OFAC's action log shows sustained high-tempo activity — Iran-related Designations (27 Jul), a Counter Terrorism/Non-Proliferation Update (30 Jul), an amended Venezuela General License (3 Aug) and further Counter Terrorism updates (5 Aug) — a reminder that Gulf-linked sanctions exposure moves quickly and needs re-screening close to each transaction.

Editorial & Verification Note: For legal and accuracy reasons, DDS Marine Group publishes officially designated vessel names, IMO numbers and ownership details only after verifying them directly against the current OFAC SDN list and primary Treasury press releases, rather than relying on secondary summaries. This keeps DDS credible and reduces the risk of publishing incorrect compliance information.

Control	Minimum Action
Vessel screening	Screen IMO, current and former names, flag history, ownership, management, operator and ISM company.
Counterparty KYC	Verify beneficial ownership, directors, trading history, address, banking and sanctions nexus.
AIS history	Review dark periods, spoofing indicators, abnormal loitering, repeated STS patterns and identity changes.
Cargo origin	Obtain documentary chain: supplier, terminal, bill of lading, certificate of origin and payment route.
Insurance / "transit fee" exposure	Confirm P&I status, war-risk cover, trading limits and — specifically this week — that no Hormuz "mandatory insurance" or transit-toll payment has been solicited from IRGC-linked entities.
Pre-operation refresh	Repeat screening immediately before nomination, fixture, arrival and commencement of STS/cargo operations.
Record preservation	Keep screenshots, reports, approvals, emails, SOF and operational instructions in the job file.

Important: A vessel being absent from one sanctions list does not automatically make the transaction acceptable. Exposure can arise through ownership, control, cargo origin, counterparties, insurers, banks, deceptive shipping practices or local-law restrictions — including, as this week's OFAC action illustrates, coerced "insurance" payments to sanctioned intermediaries. Complex cases require qualified sanctions counsel and bank/insurer confirmation.



◆ Southeast Asia & STS Operations

Malaysia-Singapore-Indonesia-Thailand-Vietnam—theMalacca-to-Pengerang corridor

This week's global data reinforces, rather than changes, the structural case set out in Issue 001: as Middle East and Black Sea routing both become less predictable, Southeast Asia's position astride the Strait of Malacca and the Singapore Strait gives it an early, practical read on how owners and charterers are actually adjusting — often before the shift shows up in headline freight assessments. This week's evidence includes Thailand's 62% increase in Hormuz-linked imports as refiners diversified sourcing (per ITC data), the widening use of Cape of Good Hope routing for cargo that would once have transited the Red Sea or Black Sea directly, and Singapore's continued position as a comparatively firm Asia/Pacific bunkering hub even as prices in the Americas have pulled back.

Market	Why It Matters to Tanker & STS Operators
Malaysia	Home to Port Klang, Malacca, Muar, Linggi and the Johor STS/bunkering corridor; the physical base of DDS Marine Group's operations.
Singapore	The region's principal bunkering, storage and blending hub; VLSFO firmer week-on-week even as crude benchmarks fell sharply.
Indonesia	Batam and Karimun sit directly opposite the Singapore Strait and remain active in STS, bunkering and offshore support.
Thailand	Recorded a 62% rise in imports of Hormuz-linked strategic products in April, per ITC data — direct evidence of trade diversion benefiting the region.
Vietnam	Growing product-import demand and a bellwether for intra-Asia clean tanker and MR trading patterns.

STS & Marine-Services Operating Standard

Operational Pillar	DDS Standard
Planning	Job-specific JPO, risk assessment, mooring plan, weather limits, communications plan and emergency response.
Vessel suitability	Compatibility review covering freeboard, manifold, fenders, hoses, mooring arrangement, vetting and cargo system.
Personnel	Qualified POAC/mooring master, pilots, surveyors, launch crew, tug support and clear command/reporting lines.
Control room	Real-time coordination with port/VTMS, owners, charterers, cargo interests, agents, tugs and service providers.
Documentation	Accurate NOR, SOF, checklists, pumping records, delay evidence, photographs and final operation report.

DDS VIEW

Southeast Asia is benefiting from Middle East and Black Sea disruption without being directly exposed to either conflict zone — a genuine structural advantage, provided the region's own screening, documentation and STS execution standards stay ahead of the volume it is absorbing. Readers who want an early, practical read on Malacca/Singapore Strait transit patterns, STS scheduling and Johor-corridor throughput should expect to find it here first.



● Freight & Rate Signals

Directional freight commentary, sourced from Hellenic Shipping News / Trading Economics / BIMCO — no proprietary broker fixtures reproduced

Baltic Dry Index — Two-Month High

The Baltic Exchange's dry bulk freight index rose for a fifth consecutive session, climbing 4.3% to 3,063 points — its highest level since 3 June — led by the larger vessel segments. The Capesize index, which typically carries 150,000-tonne iron ore and coal cargoes, surged 6.6% to 5,094 points, its highest since 3 June, while the Panamax index rose 2.2% to 2,236 points, its highest since 17 July. The Supramax index was little changed, edging down 0.1% to 1,612 points. While the BDI tracks dry bulk rather than tanker tonnage directly, the broad-based strength in the larger segments is a useful cross-check on underlying global trade volumes at a moment when tanker markets are being driven primarily by geopolitical, rather than demand-side, factors.

Dirty Tanker Volumes — Structural Tightening

As detailed in our Crude Tanker Market section, BIMCO estimates that if the reduced loading rate from Russian Black Sea and Sea of Azov ports persists, global dirty tanker volumes could fall a further 3%, on top of a 5.6% year-on-year decline already recorded in 2026. That is a supply-side tightening story running in parallel with, and largely independent of, this week's sharp fall in headline crude prices.

A Note on This Issue's Fixture Data

Issue 001 reproduced attributed broker fixture and segment-sentiment data from a named shipbroker source. This issue draws exclusively from oilprice.com, Ship & Bunker and Hellenic Shipping News, none of which publish subscription-only individual vessel fixtures; in line with our stated methodology of not reproducing proprietary broker assessments without direct attribution, we have not fabricated fixture-level detail this week. Readers requiring individual reported fixtures should continue to consult their usual broker or shipbroking-panel source; DDS Weekly Maritime Intelligence will resume publishing attributed fixture data when a suitable source is engaged.

Markets snapshot (context, not shipping-specific): Broader risk sentiment this week has been supportive of the "de-escalation" narrative behind the oil price move, consistent with reduced geopolitical risk pricing across correlated markets — see Seven-Day Outlook overleaf for how DDS is weighting this against physical tanker-market evidence.

◆ Seven-Day Outlook: 7–13 August 2026

Market	Base Case	Upside Risk	Downside Risk
Crude oil	Continued volatility in a US\$74–85/bbl range pending confirmation of a Hormuz arrangement.	Confirmed, ratified de-escalation and resumption of normal Hormuz transit volumes.	Collapse of the reported draft agreement, or a new attack on shipping or export infrastructure.
VLCC	Headline-sensitive; physical traffic lags any diplomatic progress.	Confirmed Hormuz agreement unlocking pent-up transit demand.	Renewed Hormuz incident reversing this week's price relief.
Suezmax / Black Sea	Firm on continued Ukrainian drone activity and Cape diversions.	Further escalation of Black Sea attacks, extending diversions.	A pause in Operation MoLoChKa allowing partial resumption of Russian/Kazakh Black Sea loadings.
Aframax / Red Sea	Firm, regionally exposed to Houthi activity.	Further Red Sea/Bab el-Mandeb incidents lifting war-risk premiums.	A durable reduction in Houthi attacks easing AIS/dark-transit pressure.
Clean/ products	Supportive on record refining margins and European heatwave-driven outages.	Further refinery disruption (Middle East or Europe) widening cracks further.	Rapid European refinery recovery or a sharp crude-linked demand pullback.
Bunkers	Broadly stable to firm in Asia/Pacific despite the crude pullback.	A reversal of the crude price decline pushing bunkers sharply higher.	Sustained crude weakness finally feeding through into lower VLSFO/MGO pricing.

Watch List

- Whether the reported draft Hormuz agreement is confirmed, ratified, and reflected in actual transit volumes — not just headlines.
- Further developments in Ukraine's Operation MoLoChKa and any Russian response affecting Kerch Strait/Don-Azov Canal navigation.
- Additional OFAC or EU designations targeting Hormuz "insurance"/toll schemes, the Shamkhani network, or Russian shadow-fleet entities.
- Whether Cape of Good Hope diversions (Saudi and other cargo) continue to widen or begin to normalise.
- Singapore VLSFO/MGO direction if the crude price decline persists into a second week.
- Further ITC/UNCTAD trade-flow data confirming whether Hormuz-dependent export volumes begin recovering.

DDS CONCLUSION

This week's market handed participants a rare and welcome piece of good news — a sharp, fast fall in crude prices on reported diplomatic progress. The operator's job now is to resist the temptation to relax on the back of a headline. Physical transit data, insurance terms and documented routing decisions, not oil price charts, remain the right basis for commercial and compliance decisions in the week ahead.



◆ Methodology, Sources & Disclaimer

Issue 002

DDS Weekly Maritime Intelligence combines public market data, official regulatory releases, reputable news reporting and operator-focused analysis. Freight commentary is directional and does not reproduce proprietary broker assessments or subscription-only indices.

Source	Information Used
oilprice.com, 6 Aug 2026	Brent US\$79.18/bbl, WTI US\$74.80/bbl, Murban US\$77.94/bbl (live indications); editorial coverage of Hormuz diplomatic reporting, Black Sea drone campaign, and European refining-margin developments.
Ship & Bunker (shipandbunker.com), 6 Aug 2026	Singapore, Fujairah, Rotterdam, Houston, Hong Kong, Santos, LA/Long Beach and New York VLSFO, MGO and IFO380 indications; WTI/Brent historical daily series, 28 Jul–4 Aug 2026; EU ETS compliance-cost series.
Hellenic Shipping News Worldwide (hellenicshippingnews.com), 5–6 Aug 2026	Baltic Dry Index report (source: Trading Economics); BIMCO analysis of Black Sea/ Sea of Azov dirty tanker loadings (source: BIMCO, Niels Rasmussen); ITC/ UNCTAD/WTO analysis of Hormuz trade disruption (source: United Nations); Singapore bunker price cross-check, 5 Aug 2026.
U.S. Department of the Treasury / OFAC, 29 Jul–5 Aug 2026	Iran-related designations targeting Persian Gulf Marine Insurance Company, Hormuz Safe Marine Services Authority, and tankers YEHOPE and WELL SAIL; OFAC Recent Actions log, 27 Jul–5 Aug 2026.

What's changed since Issue 001 (31 July 2026): Brent has fallen roughly 12% on reported Hormuz de-escalation; a major new Black Sea drone campaign (Ukraine's Operation MoLoChKa) has emerged, cutting Russian/Kazakh dirty tanker loadings by 62%; OFAC has designated the specific Iranian entities behind the Hormuz "mandatory insurance" scheme flagged generically in Issue 001; and new UN trade data has, for the first time, quantified the physical trade impact of six months of Hormuz disruption.

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